

CHAPTER TWENTY

Grace With Hard People

We have to draw a line in this chapter, and we have to draw it carefully, because the line we are drawing has not always been drawn well in books like this one, and the failure to draw it has hurt people.

The line is between difficult and unsafe.

A difficult person is irritating, challenging, hard to be around. A difficult person rolls their eyes when you talk in class. A difficult person is the family member who corrects everything you say. A difficult person is the friend who is going through something and is being a worse friend than usual. A difficult person is the teacher who plays favorites and you are not the favorite. A difficult person is the loud kid in the back row who, every day, derails the lesson you are actually interested in.

Grace toward difficult people is, for most of us, possible. Hard, but possible. That is what this curriculum has been preparing you for.

An unsafe person is something else entirely. An unsafe person is somebody whose presence in your life puts your physical, emotional, or psychological wellbeing at active risk. An unsafe person is the person who hits. The person who threatens. The person whose anger is unpredictable and explosive. The person who gets into your head in a way that

makes you smaller every week. The person around whom you cannot bring yourself — your real self — without consequence.

We are saying the next sentence loudly, because it is important: **Grace is not required toward unsafe people. Ever. Not in this curriculum. Not in any curriculum that means well.**

If a book asks you to extend grace toward somebody who is genuinely harming you, that book is failing you. If a teacher asks you to be the bigger person toward somebody whose presence in your life is a danger to you, that teacher is — even with the best intentions — getting it wrong. The work of grace is for you, in service of the kind of person you want to become. Grace turned into a duty to absorb harm is no longer grace. It is something else, and it has a different name, and the name is self-erasure.

You are allowed to leave situations that are unsafe. You are allowed to ask for help. You are allowed to refuse the framework of grace when the framework would require you to stay near somebody who is hurting you.

The architecture of grace assumes you, the architect, are still standing. If your safety is at risk, the architecture stops, and safety becomes the only chapter.

If anybody in your life is making you unsafe — at home, at school, online, anywhere — the right response is not grace. The right response is to tell a trusted adult. Your school counselor. A teacher. A coach. A relative. The 988 Lifeline if you do not know who else to tell. Help exists. Use it. There is no version of this book that asks you to swallow danger in the name of growth.



That said. That said.

Most of the people we have to learn to extend grace to are not unsafe. Most of them are just difficult. And there is a particular kind of grace, for the difficult-but-not-unsafe, that is one of the most demanding practices in the whole curriculum.

Priya is in math class with a kid named Owen who eye-rolls every time she talks.

Every. Single. Time. Priya raises her hand, gets called on, says her answer — and Owen, in her peripheral vision, makes a face. He does not say anything out loud. He has been careful about that. He just makes the face. Sometimes he sighs. Sometimes he mutters something to the kid next to him, who laughs.

This is not unsafe. Priya is not in danger from Owen. Priya could, if she chose, ignore him completely and the worst he would do is — eye-roll at her at a slightly higher rate.

It is, however, difficult. It costs her something every single class period. By March, Priya was raising her hand less. By the start of April, her contribution had dropped by half. By mid-April, she had stopped trying to say anything in math at all, and the cost of Owen's daily face was being paid not by Owen — Owen was fine, Owen was having a great year — but by every kid in math class who would have benefited from Priya's contributions, including, especially, Priya herself.

What does grace look like here?

It does not look like absorbing the eye-roll quietly forever. That is not grace. That is, again, a kind of self-erasure. The Compassionate Witness from Part Two would not co-sign Priya disappearing from her own math class to avoid Owen's face.

It also does not look like publicly humiliating Owen in retaliation. Retaliation is just rumor-style harm in a different

costume.

What grace looks like, here, is something more interior.

It looks like Priya, on a Wednesday in late April, making the following private decision:

Owen is a difficult person. He is not a dangerous one. The face he is making is information about him, not information about me. I am going to keep raising my hand. I am not going to perform that I do not notice him — I do notice him. I am also not going to retaliate, or report him, or make him a project. I am going to grant him the grace of not being the protagonist of my math class. I am going to be the protagonist of my math class.

That is grace-from-self-respect. It is a posture, internal, that keeps Priya in her own life without making Owen's behavior the center of it.

Priya raised her hand the next day. She gave her answer. Owen made the face. Priya, on purpose, did not look at him. She looked at the teacher. She finished her sentence. She sat down.

The next class, she did it again.

The next class, she did it again.

By the end of the week, Owen had stopped — and this is the surprise — Owen had stopped doing the face. He had not stopped because Priya had confronted him. He had stopped because the face was no longer eliciting a reaction. The face had been, in some real way, a bid. When the bid was no longer being answered, the bid lost its function.

The cohort, the next Tuesday at lunch, would note this with Priya. Sofia would say *Pri*. Owen *has stopped*. Priya would say yes. Sofia would say *Pri*. You *did the thing*. Priya would say *I did the thing*. It was so much smaller than I thought it would be. I just — I just kept raising my hand. And he ran out of fuel.

That is what grace toward a difficult-but-not-unsafe person looks like, in middle school. It is not absorbing. It is not retaliating. It is continuing to be yourself, in front of them, in the most boring possible way, until they get bored.

That works, more often than you would think.



Sometimes — and this is the harder version — grace toward a difficult person looks like grace at a distance.

You are not going to repair the relationship. You are not going to be friends. You are not, even, going to like them. You are simply going to want good things for them, in a generic, almost abstract way, while keeping your distance from them.

I want good things for you without wanting to be close to you again.

That sentence is — and most teenagers do not encounter it until much later in life — one of the most freeing sentences a human being can say. It releases you from the false binary of *either I love you or I hate you*. There is a third option, which is *I wish you well from over here*. It is grace, exercised at a distance, as a kind of generosity that does not require proximity.

Think about who, in your life, that sentence might apply to. It might be a kid who teased you in fifth grade who is now in your seventh-grade homeroom. It might be a former best friend who hurt you in sixth grade. It might be a cousin who, every Christmas, says something that lands wrong. It might be a coach you used to have. It might be — and this is the harder version — it might be a family member who has not been safe in the past and who you have, with the help of trusted adults, kept at a deliberate distance from.

For all of them, the sentence is the same.

I want good things for you without wanting to be close to you again.

It will, for most of you, take you a few years to fully be able to say it about anybody. That is fine. The point is to know the sentence exists, so that when you are ready — at fifteen, at twenty, at thirty-five — you have already met the sentence.

You met it here. In April. In seventh grade.

That is early. That is good.



A final note about grace.

Grace is not a performance.

Grace is not a thing you do so other people will say you are a good person. Grace is not a thing you do because the curriculum told you to. Grace is not a thing you do to prove anything.

Grace is, in some real way, the behavior of a person who has built the floor and the walls and the wiring of this architecture and who now, having built it, has something to give that does not require somebody to earn it. The giving is the natural extension of the building. The person who has built the architecture is, in some real way, generous by default, because the architecture itself produces generosity. There is no scarcity inside a well-built architecture. There is room for a little extra. That is what we have been building.

That is why grace comes at the end of the curriculum, not the beginning.

You cannot extend grace if you have not built the floor. You cannot extend grace if you have not built the walls. You cannot extend grace if the wiring — the empathy, the forgiveness, the impact-vs-intent, the Letter of Release — is not in.

You have built the floor. You have built the walls. The wiring is in. The grace is the natural product of the architecture.

The architecture is yours.

Carry it.

— J.A.R.